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ABSTRACT

The article offers an interpretation of comparative education as an episteme that is entangled with international relations. It does so by seeking to extract past and present forms and patterns of comparative educational thought and action from the three main traditions of international relations, namely: realism, rationalism and revolutionism. It is specifically argued that each of these three traditions offers different understandings of the nature of international society and how its main actors conduct themselves in it. These different understandings of the nature of international politics enable different ways of thinking about, and acting upon, the educational world comparatively. The implications of this interpretation of comparative education for the future are highlighted in the conclusion.

KEYWORDS

International theory; realism; rationalism; revolutionism; comparative educations; agendas of attention; presences; absences

Introduction

Comparative education has always overlapped with international relations. Not only does it take the nation-state as its point of departure, it also pursues national advancement on lessons from abroad and the development of others based on purportedly universal norms. It advocates international co-operation as a way to promote peace, delves into transnational identities and networks of knowledge production and circulation, and explores the global-local nexus. It reads the world hierarchically and even in a Manichean way, seeking to unveil exploitation and inequalities in a quest for an egalitarian world or one based on plurality and pluriversality. Even the places its specialists choose to live and work, the names they give to their professional societies and the departments they are based at, the funding made available to them and the nationalities of those serving in the editorial boards of its main journals, all signal prevailing, or shifting, international relations.

Despite such entanglements, we – in comparative education – have never used the lens of international theory in a systematic way to articulate our field's identity, history and future nor have we explored the possibilities that shifts in international relations theories and practices entail for the (re)imagining of comparative education. This is a paradox not least because such entanglements underpin our historical literature, inform our scholarly possibilities today and lead us into path-dependent futures. It is also paradoxical because we are currently – and permanently – searching for new histories of the field

(e.g. Manzon 2018), new definitions of the comparativist (e.g. Phillips 2020a), and new concepts to envision futures (e.g. Epstein 2019).

The article examines the entanglements of comparative education with international relations. It starts with a brief sketch of realism, rationalism and revolutionism, the three main traditions of thought within international relations (Wight 1992). It then argues that each of the three traditions enables certain ways of thinking about, and acting upon, the educational world comparatively, constraining other possible ways. To invoke Cowen (2000), the three traditions offer different 'readings of the global' and make possible 'multiple comparative educations'. The overall argument explored here is that what we practise as 'comparative education' is the effect of the way(s) in which we understand, consciously or unconsciously, the nature of international society and its politics, as well as how its main actors (should) conduct themselves in it.

The three traditions

The starting point for an interpretation of comparative education as an episteme that is entangled with international relations is the classic and original work of Martin Wight, the foundation of the English School of International Theory (Navari and Green 2014). In a series of lectures in the late 1950s and 1960s, reconstituted and published in the early 1990s, Wight defined international relations in terms of three traditions of thought: realism, rationalism, and revolutionism. His thinking, strengthened by recent scholarship and developments, is discussed below.

Realism

Realism is the tradition of Machiavelli. It sees the sovereign territorial state as the main actor in international politics and international politics as a struggle for power among self-interested states. In this tradition, there are no moral rules, and ought not to be, in the pursuit of power and this is associated with the nature of international society. Given the absence of a central authority to protect states from one another, realists think of international society as a self-help arena where competition and the pursuit of advantage are the basis of relations. Under conditions of anarchy, insecurity and conflict are the norm and hegemony, or a balance-of-power, is the source of stability.

International anarchy permits alliances and the formation of power blocs. It also allows expansionist imperialist politics and the exploitation of peoples that lie beyond what is in this tradition called 'international society', provided there are appropriate justifications, such as *mission civilisatrice*. Since 'international society is nothing but the great powers', who is external to it and may be subjugated and exploited is also a matter of power: 'the great powers constitute what international society there is' (Wight 1992, 32).

Power is the key concept of realists. It is the capacity of states to secure compliance and extraction externally as well as internally. Even multinational corporations and multilateral organisations, that form part of the arena within which states operate, are seen in this tradition as tools of foreign policy, furthering the interests of the most powerful state(s). In domestic policy, power is the capacity of states to impose their will within a piece of land and extract resources in support of their pursuit of dominance or survival in the international arena. As Anderson (1983) argues, however different the members of a nation

may be in terms of class, gender or ethnicity, and regardless of the actual inequality that may prevail in each, national identity presents them as a unity and grants the state the natural right to act for the nation.

Rationalism

This is the tradition of Grotius. It posits that anarchy can be mitigated by multilateralism. The assumption is that if leaders of states are brought together, they can discuss their differences and may be persuaded to suspend their immediate interests and build jointly a peaceful and prosperous international society. In rationalism, international society is not a fiction and the politics of it are a mix of conflict and co-operation. Rationalists believe that states, although not subject to a superior, still form 'a true society, but institutionally deficient' (Wight 1992, 39), whose workings could be observed in a variety of institutions that must be created for this end.

For rationalists, international law is the key institution. Not only should it be applied to all members of international society, but it should also be the mode of their interaction, not least because it sets the rules that restrain states in their dealings with one another. Since power is not self-justifying, law is for rationalists the outer source that it needs to be turned into authority. In Wight's words, authority 'is power that is justified by consonance with moral principles; the capacity of states to secure assent and co-operation ... , internally and externally' (107). Yet not all states are full or equal members of a 'world-wide legal community' (72). Under the doctrine of authority, the strong members are legally responsible as 'trustees' for the advancement or development of the weak ones.

Authority, a key concept for rationalists, has provided rationales for the creation of multilateral organisations before and especially since World War II. Some rationalists (e.g. Keohane and Nye 1972) posit that these organisations enhance the functionality and realisation of international society, defining international politics not just as a matter of inter-national relations but also in transnational terms. Others (e.g. Keck and Sikkink 1998; Barnett and Finnemore 2004) point out that since they are actors in their own right and draw power from 'ideas', multilateral organisations and transnational groups complement, expand and even transcend states. Under conditions where authority is dispersed and power is shared by many actors, some others (e.g. McGrew 2010) stress that nation-states assert their power as a tool of negotiation and call for more rules to further constrain their behaviour in international society.

Revolutionism

This is the tradition of Kant. It sees politics not as relations among states but among individuals and groups of which states are composed. The ultimate reality is a universal human community, the expression of which may require humans 'to harden international society into a worldstate, to define it and constitute it as a super-state' (Wight 1992, 41). Force is a necessary concept for revolutionists. It is the capacity to overthrow power, in the name of revolutionist doctrine, in order to carry out the necessary reconstruction.

Revolutionism, like rationalism, appeals to morality, but what is meant by this is not the rules that require states to behave as good members of society, but the moral unity of

interest and society that requires all to work for the human fraternity. 'The deepest element in the Kantian tradition', notes Bull (in Wight, xvii), 'is the moral passion to abolish suffering'. In this tradition, the world is divided between those who are faithful to the vision of a worldstate and those who stand in its way. The faithful 'are cosmopolitan rather than 'internationalist' and their 'overriding obligation to give effect to it [world-state] ... has a 'missionary character' (Wight 1992, 8). The rest of universal human community is assimilated into the oppressed who ought to align themselves with the faithful by undermining the old order in support of the new.

Exemplified by the religious revolutions of the sixteenth and seventeenth centuries, the French revolution of the eighteenth century and the totalitarian revolutions of both left and right in the twentieth century, elements of this tradition can be found in more recent times in neo-Marxist approaches to imperialism and neo-colonialism (e.g. Galtung 1971; Wallerstein 1974) and in postcolonial/decolonial analyses of what came to be portrayed as 'globalisation' (e.g. Mignolo 2011).

Realist comparative educations

From the perspective of realism, a range of possibilities in terms of thinking about, and acting upon, the educational world comparatively, have emerged historically, with many surviving into the present. Realism gave rise to a 'modernist' comparative education (Cowen 2014) that does not simply focus on 'national systems, state-run, of education' (Dale and Robertson 2009) and read social space in 'territorial and geopolitical' terms (Larsen and Beech 2014). Under conditions of anarchy where a nation-state's strength in global competitions is often ascribed to its education system, comparative education has emerged as a pragmatic, action-oriented tool whose aim is to help states maximise their power capabilities and gain or maintain their position in the international arena. Beech (2006) articulates the 'practical value' of the field as follows: a 'problem' is identified at home, 'solutions' are sought abroad, and a 'successful' policy is imported and implemented after being 'adapted' to domestic peculiarities.

The origins of this view of the field are traced to the interstate rivalries of the nineteenth century. At that time, Britain, France, (Imperial) Germany, and the USA were the main rivals, and assuming that their strength was causally linked to education, 'they greedily and curiously wanted to learn from each other' (Tröhler 2023, 7). Greed and curiosity produced 'educational commissions' (Phillips 2020a) and 'visiting inquiries' (Lawn 2015) and reports about the rivals' public system of education. An early example is French intellectual Victor Cousin's tour of Prussian schools in 1831 and his reports to François Guizot, the education minister. Prussia, the world's first 'educating State' (Nóvoa 2000), provided a powerful solution to the problem of nation-building and attracted international attention in mid-nineteenth century.

The idiom of learning from 'others' was consolidated by Michael Sadler at the turn of the twentieth century. Sadler, like Matthew Arnold and Robert Hughes, was concerned not just about losing the battle of nation-building through education reform but mostly about a growing American and German industrial superiority, 'which needed to be countered by a much-improved British education' (Lawn 2015, 218). To sustain Britain's position as 'the Workshop of the World', the newly created Office of Special Inquiries and Reports of the Department of Education produced, under the directorship of Sadler,

volumes of work on aspects of education in Britain's rivals, notably Germany's secondary and vocational education (Phillips 2020b).

The idiom of learning from 'others' extended as the international arena absorbed new members. When the Japanese were faced with the 'Black Ships' of the US navy in the 1850s, which revealed their technological and military inferiority, they saw education as one of the 'secret keys' of Western superiority (Passin 1965). To gain international position, they looked to the US for a school system, France for administrative models of education, and Germany became a model for a university (Tanaka 2005). The Soviet launch of Sputnik in 1957 caused a similar shock to the Americans challenging their belief that they had taken the global lead in science, technology, and education after World War II. To recover their leading position, they embraced the USSR's stress on science, mathematics, and languages to invigorate high schools and universities (Tröhler 2013). Translated as a failure in wider educational terms, the Sputnik shock also turned their attention to England's child centred pedagogy to revitalise elementary schools (Ravitch 1983).

Anarchy also enables the negative depiction of 'others' as a means of validating the position of the 'self' in the international arena. Nowhere is this more evident than in the two Germanies and the two antagonistic blocs they exemplified. At the heart of the Cold War, the 'German Institute for International Education' in Frankfurt and the 'Research Unit for Comparative Education' at the University of Bochum were created in West Germany. Under the headship of Wolfgang Mitter (Frankfurt) and Oskar Anweiler (Bochum), the two Centres aligned their research to West Germany's anti-communist strategy and produced comparisons between West and East Germany, with the aim of identifying differences and preserving a distance between the two systems (Waterkamp 2008). Also founded at the heart of the Cold War, the comparative education sections of the academies of pedagogical sciences in the USSR and other socialist countries similarly aligned their work with the bloc's anti-capitalist strategy. These sections produced studies on education in capitalist countries 'with the sole purpose of documenting how far capitalist educational systems lagged behind socialist ones' (Steiner-Khamsi 2006, 40).

Thus realism explains more than just 'cross-national attraction in education' (Phillips 1989), the inclusion of state administrators in our iconography (Phillips 2020a) and the making of 'reference societies' (Schriewer 1990) and 'counter reference societies' (Takayama 2018a). It explains the rise of political crises and sudden international attention to 'un-noticed' countries, such as Finland, and a frenzy of research on their 'successful' education systems (Pereyra, Kotthoff, and Cowen 2011), as well as the projection of 'eager' and 'slow learners' given the willingness of 'low-performers' in international assessments to emulate the models of 'high-performers' (Grek 2019). It also explains the field's 'scientific turn' in the 1970s that was aimed at perfecting policy import (Silova 2012), and thus, at increasing the possibility of international ascendancy or survival. Yet, it also made possible the articulation of opposition to the reading of comparative education as 'a useful science' (Cowen 2006), envisioning it instead as 'self-knowledge born of the awareness of others' (Bereday 1964, 6).

In a world where nation-states came to be seen as culturally distinct and their education as 'the outward expression of national character' (Hans 1958, 9), the field's forces and factors literature escaped the 'trap' of instant practicality and focused on 'the causes of things'. In this view, realism gives rise to one of the main puzzles of the

field – how to grasp the ‘context’ of an education system (Crossley 2000) – and equates national character with educated identity. Even though it avoided the trap of usefulness, this literature still took the national as its focal point and treated educated identities as ‘essentialist’, reifying the nation-state as a ‘natural’ identification (Klerides 2009). In line with national power, educated identities were also treated as ‘unified’, a view that solidified the nation-state as a homogenous actor in international politics and legitimised exclusionary definitions of ‘national citizenship’ along masculine, white, middle-class, and heterosexual lines (Klerides and Carney 2021). By reproducing national power even in seemingly international education performance data (Tröhler, Piattoeva, and Pinar 2022), the field has also centrally positioned itself in imperialist projects of instructing ‘others’ to become like the ‘self’: ‘civilised’, ‘developed’ and ‘efficient’.

Realism produces the field’s ‘darker side’ (Hayhoe and Mundy 2008): its participation in ‘civilising’ the ‘uncivilised’. Under anarchy, states also wrestle for the expansion of their overseas power. In their struggles for expansion abroad, they locate the exportation of their education at the core of the political control and economic exploitation of foreign lands and peoples that are depicted to lie beyond the ‘international society’. Comparative education was entangled with these expansionist processes. At Teachers College, Paul Monroe and Isaac Kandel aligned their work to the US imperialist priorities and engaged in the ‘advancement’ of ‘backward’ peoples through education (Takayama 2018b). In accepting the ‘burden’ of ‘uplifting’ the world’s ‘less fortunate’ to the ‘advanced’ standard of living and, after World War II, of creating ‘responsible’ governments and citizenry, these and other scholars based at the Colonial Department (1927–52) and the Department of Education in Tropical Areas (1952–73) at the Institute of Education in London (Unterhalter and Kadiwal 2022), surveyed education in the American and European empires, supported the policy work of colonial governments and trained education leaders and teacher trainers from the colonies. In participating in ‘survey expeditions’, ‘expert missions’ and ‘exchange programs’ (Takayama 2018b; Unterhalter and Kadiwal 2022), they were simultaneously advancing their academic careers and our field’s position within universities.

Realism also gives rise to the field’s ‘development turn’ (Steiner-Khamsi 2006): its participation in ‘developing’ the ‘underdeveloped’. The fall of territorial empires was replaced by a new race for global domination where the US and the USSR struggled over their patronage of newly independent countries. Education was again seen as a key tool in the battle to win these countries over and this brought about changes in the field. Steiner-Khamsi points out that with the two superpowers targeting the ‘Third World’, most available funding and much of the focus of comparative education was directed to ‘developing’ countries. In part, the aim was to justify ‘intervention’ by depicting these countries as ‘lagging behind’ capitalist or socialist ones. The study of education in these countries was also aimed at making ‘country experts’ who could serve as ‘technical advisers’ for the new governments, helping the ‘modernisation’ of their countries and securing their political support. Since education in ‘developing’ countries was seen as inferior to be compared with education in capitalist or socialist countries, single-country, area-specific studies have emerged as a main method of comparative inquiry, along with institutional changes. The Department of Education in Tropical Areas at the Institute of Education was renamed to Education in Developing Countries (Unterhalter and Kadiwal 2022), while the word ‘international’ was inserted into the name of the US

Comparative Education Society to reflect in part the field's shift to international intervention and its opening up to international organisations (Epstein 2016).

International organisations also shifted their attention to development during the Cold War with the support of US governments and institutions. The UNESCO International Institute for Educational Planning (IIEP) was created in 1963 with Philip Coombs, a former Assistant Secretary of State for Education, as its first director, and with the World Bank and the Ford Foundation as its main partners and donors. The Organisation for Economic Cooperation and Development (OECD) emerged out of the Organisation for European Economic Cooperation (OEEC) in 1961 which was itself created by the US in 1948 to administer the European Recovery Programme. These institutions were established to offer technical assistance in educational planning in developing (IIEP) and European (OEEC/OECD) countries for the purposes of economic growth (Elfert 2017, 2019). The importance of educational planning in economic growth was based on a technocratic and economistic view of education as an investment, a view that itself emerged out of the economics of education movement taking place in US government and academic circles after Sputnik and having at its core science, mathematics, and language(s): PISA's focus (Tröhler 2013). Started by C. Arnold Anderson in 1958, the Comparative Education Center at the University of Chicago was instrumental in fusing together comparative education and the economics of education (Brehm 2023). Together with US-initiated and funded international projects (e.g. Marshall Plan in Western Europe, Alliance for Progress in Latin America, Mediterranean Regional Project) and US-dominated international organisations, the Center helped spread human capital theories in the world, paving the way of what came to be seen as 'globalisation'.

The field's entanglement with development is cloaked today in neoliberal globalisation. Invented to discredit European imperialism, promote American hegemony in the western bloc and contain communism, the 'development paradigm' has become dominant after the collapse of the Soviet Union (Tikly 2004). Comparative education has gone through a similar transition: its focus has shifted away from technical assistance in educational planning for economic development and towards the making of 'best practices' that (allegedly) typify 'efficient' education systems in support of the post-Fordist regimes of accumulation and their dogma of knowledge for economic growth (Brehm 2023). Such neoliberal economistic thinking about education characterises much of the work of international organisations today, teaching 'others' how to become 'efficient' and solidifying American power.

Yet realism does not shape the field's praxis only in ameliorative and interventionist terms, but also in terms of hermeneutics. This is not limited to context-based interpretations of education but also includes the rigorous analysis of education mobilities through the theoretical lens of 'transfer, translation and transformation' (Cowen 2009). The analysis of these complex processes is still shaped by national and international power. Thus transfer is normally studied as a movement across a national border, for example the transfer of the Humboldt model of university from Germany to Japan and the US in the nineteenth century (Tanaka 2005). International power hierarchies made it also possible for ideas to traverse multiple borders, as in the case of the technocratic and economistic view of education during the Cold War, spreading from the US to Western Europe first and then to South Europe and Latin America (Elfert 2019), or in the case of adapted education. Developed around 1890 in the US South, this model

was transferred to the African colonies of Britain and France in the early twentieth century by American missions and colonial governments; in the 1930s it was used for the education of the indigenous peoples of the Pacific, and in the 1950s diffused wherever the British administration felt pressured to deal with the education of 'retarded' cultures (Steiner-Khamsi 2000).

Rationalist comparative educations

Not only these imaginaries of inter-national borrowing and lending but also other realist motifs, including our nation-based understanding of the contexts of education and what it means to be educated, are rendered problematic from the perspective of rationalism, giving rise to different ways of thinking about, and acting upon, the educational world comparatively. As an effect of the rise of global institutions and mechanisms of governance, there emerged within the field a belief that comparative education was 'at the end of an era' at the beginning of the twenty-first century (Carney 2010). Many within and outside the field argued that since states are now locked into thickening and overlapping webs of transnational relations and concede part of their power to supra-national bodies of authority, the national can no longer be the focus of all analytical attention of the field. It was also argued that it is not possible to continue treating the state as the only, or most critical, actor in education nor equating education with mass schooling. As Dale and Robertson (2009) put it, an emphasis on national education systems as the core interest of the field in a globalising world is 'not just methodological *nationalism*, but methodological *statism*, and methodological *educationism*' (1113).

Shifting their attention from 'government to governance', comparativists began to analyse education in terms of the idea that authority is dispersed in the global system, and thus, as the product of complex and often asymmetrical and unpredictable interaction in transnational and even global networks of knowledge production. Some focus on the role of supra-national states, such as the European Union (e.g. Alexiadou 2007), and international organisations, such as the World Bank (e.g. Klees, Samoff, and Stromquist 2012), in 'knowledge alliances' and 'partnerships in/for education', while others focus on philanthropy, business, and NGOs (e.g. Verger, Lubienski, and Steiner-Khamsi 2016). Some others are interested in international large-scale assessments (e.g. Pereyra, Kotthoff, and Cowen 2011) and their impact on education in national settings (e.g. Martens and Niemann 2013). Thus in addition to non-state actors playing a role in policy, comparativists (e.g. Morris 2012) explore why and how 'big data' are selectively instrumentalised by governments in the reform of their education systems. In an effort to capture the spatial complexity of the dispersal of authority, some comparativists promote relational readings of space, such as 'policyscapes' (Carney 2009) and 'network spatiality' (Larsen and Beech 2014).

A strand of the field (e.g. Klerides 2018; Brehm 2023) extends backwards the study of governance highlighting the participation of the field in peace politics and the effect of the rationalist dogma of international co-operation on its development. Together with earlier texts (e.g. Halls 1990), this literature shows that being perceived in ameliorative terms, comparative education was integrated into the work of global (e.g. UNESCO) and regional (e.g. the Council of Europe) organisations and emerged as an instrument for the reduction of ethnocentrism in education systems and the promotion of

international understanding. The belief that the field can help transcend nationalism and foster internationalism was built on the work not only of *L'UNESCO oubliée* (Renoliet 1999), the League of Nations' Organisation of Intellectual Co-operation, but also of regional organisations such as *Föreningarna Norden* and the International Conferences of the American States. The interwar work of these organisations established comparison as a way to remove omissions, distortions and stereotypes from history schoolbooks and constitute inter-subjectively objective school knowledges, which served the vision of 'the international mind'. This subjectivity was for Alferd Zimmern, the first deputy director of the International Institute of Intellectual Co-operation, 'a general mentality among the peoples of the world more appropriate to cooperation than the nationalistic mentality' (Klerides 2018, 227).

The field's reformist commitment to the democratisation of societies and the betterment of human lives through education in the aftermath of the human tragedy of the war facilitated further its integration into these organisations, especially UNESCO, whose early focus on 'lifelong learning' embraced these aims for education (Elfert 2023). Nowhere is this commitment of the field more evident than in the work of Joseph Lauwerys, the first professor of comparative education in Britain (1947) and the first president of the Comparative Education Society in Europe (CESE) (1961–67). Cowen (2020) notes that Lauwerys, one of the first consultants of UNESCO, was deeply committed to 'international understanding', as well as 'democratic ideals' and 'scientific humanism'.

The entanglement of the field with the international politics of peace, democracy and humanism played a crucial role in its institutionalisation inside universities and as a distinct professional domain. As comparativists (e.g. Brian Holmes) participated in UNESCO's expert meetings and educational missions across the world, a specialist Department of Comparative Education was created at the London's Institute of Education (Unterhalter and Kadiwal 2022). Likewise, CESE emerged out of the politics of international co-operation in 1961 and notably Lauwerys's collaboration with Saul Robinsohn, the Director of the UNESCO Institute for Education and a past president of CESE (1971–72). One of CESE's early aims was to promote international academic exchanges in the reform of European education (Cowen 2020).

Rationalism produces more than just a focus on governance in the field; the framing of its praxis in pacifist terms and in terms of democratic realisation and individual potential fulfilment; a consolidation of comparative and international ('internationalist') education (or international and intercultural comparative education in Germany) as its name; urgent questions as to how it relates to intercultural education and global policy studies; and a critique of marginalising the nation-state (Tröhler, Piattoeva, and Pinar 2022).

In a world where international, transnational, and supranational actors strive to reshape education systems without however being seen as violating national sovereignty, comparative education has emerged as 'a mode of governance'. As Nóvoa and Yariv-Mashal (2003) point out, benchmarking, the practice that is widely used by multilateral organisations to measure the 'efficiency' of education systems, is not a mere method of enquiry. This practice – and the comparability that forms part of it – is also a political solution instigating, from a distance and via denotations of scientific objectivity, education reform. In most cases, the indicators, standards or desired outcomes against which efficiency is measured, are themselves the outcome of comparison, representing the

former (indicators, standards, outcomes), the latest stage of development in education and, the latter (comparison), the scientifically neutral mode through which development is created, validated, spread and enforced.

Rationalism centrally positions the field in the development of an 'institutionally deficient international society' where its collective and individual, state and non-state members contribute to it in different ways but often through the same medium: comparison. Instead of a tool that aspires to contribute to the improvement of the 'self' on lessons from 'others' and the development of 'others' on the exemplar of the 'self', comparative education becomes, under the dictates of authority, a tool for the construction and validation, as well as diffusion and enforcement of the international(ist) 'self'. In this view, rationalism explains the belief that 'we are all comparativists now' (Nóvoa and Yariv-Mashal 2003), the increase of opportunities for international consultancy and contract-funded research in the field, why much of comparative research takes place outside universities, and the call to distinguish 'academic' from 'applied' forms of comparative education (Cowen 2006).

Since the image of international society and the 'self' is held to be primarily couched in neoliberal economic terms (Elfert 2023; Brehm 2023), comparative education has evolved from a tool of peace, democracy, and humanism into one that is charged with the making of 'efficient' individuals and education systems for productivity ends. Output-related efficiency and economic productivity may be dominant but there are many other 'meaning constellations in the world society' (Schriewer 2012) as the proliferation of educated identities indicates.

In a world where nation-states are no longer the sole sources of identity, the field's normative and analytic work on what it means to be educated is extended beyond the nation and focuses on issues of identity plurality and intersectionality (Klerides and Carney 2021). Markers of identity such as gender, ethnicity, region, ability, sexuality, consumerism, and occupation, have become units of transnational and even global analysis and elaboration by a wide range of global and local, state and non-state actors, making the study of the educated person in comparative education a complex and often unpredictable venture (Klerides and Zembylas 2017). The educated person is not simply seen as a product of national cultures but is also associated with other topics, such as intercultural competence (e.g. the Council of Europe), respect for human rights (e.g. UNESCO), ecological sensitivity (e.g. Greenpeace) and economic productivity (e.g. OECD). A specific concept put forward as an umbrella term of all these different fragments of the educated person, is 'global citizenship'. This concept, echoing as well as reinforcing the idea of an 'international society', has become a major focus of attention – and criticism – within the field not least because of its 'vagueness' (e.g. Oxley and Morris 2013; Hobson and Silova 2014).

Transfer is also recast as a complex, pluralist and often unpredictable process, further legitimising the idea of an 'international society' where power is shared. Beech (2009) points out that the state is still a key player in the business of transfer in a globalising world, but other actors are also involved, such as regional blocs, multilateral organisations, NGOs, policy entrepreneurs and multinational corporations, whose work crosscuts and even bypasses state divisions. Under the mantra of 'evidence-based policy', all these actors are networked in complex ways to formulate and implement policy and the outcomes of their interaction are held not to be always predictable. To grasp how and why knowledge about education moves – and shape-shifts as it moves – between the

diverse scales of global governance, Beech, among others (e.g. Steiner-Khamsi and Waldow 2012; Beech and Artopoulos 2016), calls for new theories and concepts, questioning the binaries of 'import-export' and 'borrowing-lending'. In light of such calls, theories such as Actor-Network Theory are increasingly used in the field (e.g. Schulte 2012) to analyse the multiple actors and networks involved in knowledge production and circulation. Also, new concepts such as 'travelling policies' and 'flowing discourses' are devised to acknowledge the 'unclear origins' and 'trajectories' of many of today's neoliberal reforms, while the concepts of 'harmonisation' and 'standardisation' are used to explore the 'alignment' of state policies with those of the regional educational space they inhabit (Steiner-Khamsi and Waldow 2012).

If realism gives rise to 'a large rift' between those implementing and those studying transfer (Steiner-Khamsi 2004), rationalism enables 'the world culture debate' (Carney, Rappleye, and Silova 2012): a dispute among those studying how and under what conditions ideas travel and take form as practices. The world culture theorists (e.g. Meyer and Ramirez 2000) see transfer as a consensual process of internalisation, according to which Western ideas are appropriated and enacted by individuals, nation-states and organisations as a rational undertaking in their realisation of belonging to a 'world society'. Instead of documenting isomorphism, critics of convergence (e.g. Schriewer 2012) explore the local variations of global phenomena. They contest the argument of actors adopting the same universal messages unreflexively and irrespective of history, identity, or national context, and seek to foreground the indigenisation of global ideas including their rejection. For exponents of 'the global/local nexus' thesis, transfer is not just a mimetic and normative practice but also a product of coercion and unequal power relations.

Revolutionist comparative educations

From the point of view of revolutionism, the whole idea of education and not just the mobility of ideas is examined in terms of domination and resistance, giving rise to forms of comparative educational thought and action that differ from realism and rationalism. Revolutionism made possible the conception of comparative education as a moral undertaking aimed at uncovering inequalities and setting the possibility for a just, or 'equitable redistribution', to use the words of UNESCO's Faure Report of 1972 (Elfert 2017), of political power and economic production in the world.

In the 1970s and early 1980s, comparativists such as Carnoy (1974), Altbach (1977), Altbach and Kelly (1978), Arnove (1980a; 1980b) and Watson (1982), rejected the dominant Western interpretation of the 'underdevelopment' of 'the Third World' as a 'lack' that was projected by modernisation and human capital theories. Instead, they adopted a dependency lens whose aim was to highlight Western exploitation and the constraints of the Western-enacted capitalist world order to poor countries and the poor within the West as the real reasons for their underdevelopment, envisaging, at the same time, social transformation: 'How do we change a society that colonizes people to accept dominated roles, roles that are defined by a powerful, self-perpetuating group?' (Carnoy 1974, 369).

This neo-Marxist lens places the work of dependency comparativists within the realm of revolutionism not just because of their concern for subversion and emancipation or their underlying appeal to morality. Through this lens, the dependency literature

moves the field away from the view of the state as a unit of comparison and a unitary actor in world politics. Instead, the notions of 'centre' and 'periphery' are used according to which the shared interests of those at the 'centre of the centre' and 'centre of the periphery' are a main source of exploitation for peripheral groups. For dependency comparativists, 'dominant' and 'subordinate' groups at centres and peripheries of capitalism are the real actors in international politics and international politics are the struggles of the subordinate to overthrow the oppression of the dominant and reconstruct the world in socialist lines.

From the centre – periphery perspective, these comparativists depict Western models of education to have been imposed upon colonial peripheries as part of imperial domination and sustained to perpetuate the control of colonised peoples. As territorial colonialism ended, neo-colonial domination patterns are held to have emerged, according to which metropolitan and peripheral institutions, as well as multilateral organisations and philanthropic foundations pursued the convergence of 'developing' countries with Western norms of education, with the aim of maintaining or enacting new relationships of exploitation between centre and periphery. Even within imperial and post-imperial centres themselves, schools are related to the aim of developing and reproducing an unjust reproduction of power among social groups.

Revolutionism produces more than just a view of the education system in inegalitarian terms, or of the state as unequal relations among social groups. It generates a range of other key features that defined comparative education as 'a noteworthy radical genre' of scholarship (Kazamias 2001) at the moment of decolonisation. It gives rise to a view of the education system as a tool for radical transformation by which 'egalitarian' societies can be enacted via either 'violent revolutions' or 'democratically'. As Carnoy (1974) notes, '*in the transition toward the reconstructed society, 'free' schools or 'liberation' schools may be the strongest element in decolonizing people in the society and breaking down its hierarchical structure*' (367–8). Such ideas inform later comparative works (e.g. Carnoy and Samoff 1990) that focus on the study of social revolutions in dependent capitalist, colonial and newly independent countries of the Third World, bringing to the fore the reconstructionist role given to education in the transition from capitalism to socialism.

Also, revolutionism accounts for a view of educated identities during colonial times along the discriminatory lines of 'elite-academic' vs 'practice-oriented' subjectivities (Klerides and Carney 2021) and a reading of educational transfer not just as a tool of domination but, more crucially, as one of counter-domination and class struggle. Kaiser et al. (2015) show in their study how Third World revolutionary governments borrowed the Soviet model of 'Workers' Faculties' from socialist countries as an instrument for crafting 'socialist intelligentsia' out of worker-peasant classes to replace the 'politically untrustworthy bourgeoisie'. Above all, revolutionism shapes the field's praxis in missionary terms. Since the oppressed in the centre and periphery do not realise that they inhabit a world created to keep them in subservience, it is the duty of dependency comparative scholars to help them 'see' the role of education in (re)producing their 'servitude of the mind' (Altbach 1977) and thus assist in the creation of nonhierarchical societies.

The postcolonial/decolonial strand of comparative education (e.g. Crossley and Tikly 2004; Ninnes and Burnett 2004; Unterhalter 2009; Takayama, Sriprakash, and Connell 2017) assumes a similar duty in a 'globalising' world, centrally positioning the field in projects of unveiling coloniality and aspirations of enacting decoloniality. This strand, like

dependency, departs from the assumption that the colonial experience is not over; rather it continues to shape the world. But unlike dependency, it rejects socialism as the logic of the redistribution of power in the world on the grounds that it claims a similar universality to capitalism. This strand also denounces the field's mainstream approaches to globalisation because they ignore the colonial legacy and silence the 're-Westernisation' of the world according to the neo-capitalist doctrine of knowledge for wealth accumulation.

From a dismissal of modernity as universality, a specific agenda of attention emerges in the field that also falls within the revolutionist tradition, not least its motif of the division of the world between 'proponents' and 'opponents' of power redistribution. Echoing revolutionism, the unjust distribution of power in the world is not simply examined by postcolonial/decolonial comparativists as something to be identified and 'corrected' incrementally. The scope is a 'distinct break' with 'the Western horizon', 'an admittedly ambitious move to replace both the kosmos and episteme ... of existing research' in order 'to set up the possibility of pluriversality' (Silova, Rappleye, and Auld 2020, 22).

In unveiling coloniality, postcolonial/decolonial comparative education first delves into former colonies. Some (e.g. Ninnies and Burnett 2004; Unterhalter 2009) bring to the fore how postcolonial efforts to change colonial schools suffer from enduring stratification along the colonially manipulated categories of race and ethnicity. Others (e.g. Crossley and Tikly 2004) highlight that such efforts suffer from being subject to the whims of post-colonial indigenous elites that still align their interests with those of their former masters rather than of their own people. Some others (e.g. Klerides 2022) note that the colonial encounter is still evident in the ways international data are used in national reform: while such data are admired as a promise of salvation from troubles, they are simultaneously feared as a threat to cultural identity.

From the task of unveiling the ways in which the persistent experiences of coloniality are not known, another body of scholarship focuses on the effects of colonialism on colonising nations. Coulby, Gundara, and Jones (1997) explore the questioning of the Eurocentrism of school knowledge by multiculturalists and their conflict with cultural restorationists who are held to stand in the way of the making of racially and ethnically inclusive societies by reasserting the 'traditional' character of schooling. That Western policy makers are only now coming to recognise the global dimensions of their education is for Silova, Rappleye, and Auld (2020) another sign of coloniality: those from non-Western settings have been thinking about their own education as globally entangled since the advent of modernity. Even Western media responses to Asian PISA high performers are shown to be shaped by historically and geopolitically informed racial anxieties about Asians being both an inspiration and a threat, continuing the legacy of orientalism (Takayama 2018a; You 2019; Grey and Morris 2022).

Also, deconstructing coloniality and setting the possibility for decoloniality entails the uncovering of the re-Westernisation of the world, a task that signifies a reconceptualisation of globalisation in revolutionist terms. Rather than dispersed authority, global governance is recast as a 'new imperialism' (Tikly 2004). Governance bodies (e.g. OECD) are refashioned as 'neo-empires of knowledge' (Klerides, Kotthoff, and Pereyra 2014) and 'subtler empires' (Cowen 2018), which have moved education from the 'civilising' paradigm of colonialism to the neocolonial paradigm of 'development' (Tikly 2004), and governance forms (e.g. PISA) as 'banal imperialism', which reproduces the 'othering' of the non-West via the routine production and everyday circulation of 'big data' (Silova and Auld 2019).

Comparison is also recast along revolutionist lines. Instead of a 'mode of governance', it is re-read as a tool with a dual function: a tool that creates a new developmental model of education that is 'as Eurocentric as its predecessor' (Tikly 2004) as it still links education to economic growth, and, a tool that enforces this neoliberal outcomes-based model on the non-West by conveying the message that they need to 'catch up' with the West (Silova and Auld 2019). Likewise, global citizenship is redefined from a 'vague concept' to an educated identity marked by Western neoliberal economic doctrines, such as competitiveness and entrepreneurship, while transfer as a unidirectional process – from North/West to South/East – rather than a 'complex' process of 'unclear' origins, 'multiple' mobilities and 'unpredictable' translations (Silova, Rappleye, and Auld 2020).

The field itself and not just some of its 'unit ideas' (Cowen 2006; 2014) is recast from the position of revolutionism. Rather than being labelled by the term 'modernist', comparative education is projected as an 'imperial-colonial' episteme whose origins – often located in Marc-Antoine Jullien's 1816/17 plan – are rooted in European expansion and its associated practices of travel, observation, and classification of difference (Sobe 2017). Its entanglement with coloniality is still evident today not just in being positioned at the heart of the making of a Western neo-liberal world order in education. It is also manifest in the choice of English as the language of the field's knowledge production and circulation, the use of Western theories to interpret non-Western realities and the use of non-Western realities as a source of empirical data and case studies for Western theorisation, as well as the domination of British, North American, and Western European scholars in the editorial teams of the influential journals of the field (Takayama, Sriprakash, and Connell 2017).

In light of this reading of the field, its praxis is not limited to unveiling coloniality as a necessary condition of decoloniality. Setting the possibility for decoloniality also entails giving voice to the subaltern and its ways of knowing; for example, by pointing to South-South knowledge exchanges (Hickling-Hudson 2004), by ascribing credibility to Eastern models of pedagogy (Komatsu and Rappleye 2017), or by highlighting indigenous resistance to colonial policies (Klerides 2021). Above all, creating conditions for decoloniality means delinking the field from its Western horizon and linking it to southern theory and other alternative epistemologies (Takayama, Sriprakash, and Connell 2017).

Conclusion

Since comparative education is entangled with international relations, a future of the field ought to focus on how these are currently shifting. Undoubtedly imbalances of power will endure in a universal human community and a strand of comparative education will carry on unveiling exploitation and discrimination, seeking to set the possibility of a just or plural-world. There is no doubt that another strand will continue exploring and endorsing the dispersal of power and authority in an institutionally deficient international society as a way of its incremental realisation and the containment of state power. As the post-Cold War American power is increasingly challenged by Russia and China, the field ought to re-balance itself and bring rivalries in the international arena back in its agenda of attention. Emerging scholarship (e.g. Papastephanou 2022; Tröhler, Piattoeva, and Pinar 2022) reminds us that not only have we forgotten this motif, but we have participated in its suppression not least by means of ahistorical analysis. Emergent scholarship (e.g. Mignolo

2011) further reminds us that in focusing on western imperialism, we have also ignored other forms of imperialism that are taking place in the world.

The global hegemony of the US is opposed today by Russia's aggressive behaviour. The US and its western allies have not just condemned Moscow's use of military force in Ukraine, they have simultaneously rediscovered the value of state independence and territorial integrity along with the national patriotic idiom. As Papastephanou (2022) notes, 'the 'we' of Western visions of political configurations has come full circle: from the Westphalian roots of the state and the late-modern apotheosis of sovereignty to the post-modern whole-sale incrimination of the nation-state and now to sovereignty being again in fashion' (82). What ideas will (re)surface as a result of the return of the sovereign territorial state in western politics and how will they be linked to 'the politics of fear' (Wodak 2015) to confront the return of the nuclear threat? How might education systems be called upon to support or hinder the US – Russia rivalry for dominance or survival in the international arena? And what sorts of comparative educational thought and action will emerge out of a possible return to bloc politics where Russia and China create a common front against the US-led West on the ideological grounds of a split between autocracy and democracy?

The global hegemony of the US is also challenged by China's economic power. Even though Beijing rejects the Washington's economic dictates, it seeks not to transform the world economic order but rather wrestle the control of it from the US. The combination of unabated capitalist expansion and Confucian familism-style nationalism is a manifestation of Chinese commitment to this order albeit with East Asian features. As Mignolo (2011) puts it, while China's 'dewesternisation' shares with the 'rewesternisation' of the US 'the 'survival of capitalism', the confrontation takes place at other levels of the colonial matrix of power: the sphere of authority, of knowledge, and of subjectivity' (47). If China takes the leadership of the global economy and organisations, and forms a new bloc in East and Southeast Asia, what education rhetorics and institutions will be advanced to support or hinder its hegemony *vis-à-vis* the US-led western bloc and the 'rest' of the world? What patterns of comparative education and spaces for criticality will emerge as a result of the Sino-American rivalry and even a broader rivalry between a US-led western and an anti-American bloc formed by China and Russia?

Before moving forward, however, we must first look back at the field's archive. There is still a wide range of matters of international relations, such as war, revolution, intervention, blocism, peace, diplomacy, and alterity, whose connections to the field are yet to be examined and constituted. There is also a wide range of sub- or in-between theories from the spectrum of realism, rationalism and revolutionism to choose from to unearth and create connections. For example, how can we articulate the links of educated identities in the Balkan peninsula to inter-state rivalries for the Ottoman European territories in the late nineteenth and early twentieth centuries from the perspective of aggressive realism? Or the centrality of educational transfer in the international politics of reconciliation in the same region in the late twentieth and early twenty-first centuries from the angle of revolutionary idealism? This suggests that the consolidation of the thesis that comparative education is inextricably interwoven with international relations ought to be another future of the field.

In this article, the field's connections to international relations are approached from the angle of Wight's international theory. Despite being 'ideal types' and because they are 'unduly Eurocentric' (Bull in Wight 1992, xviii, xxii), the three traditions are useful in

opening futures while generating a sense of our (predominantly Anglo-American) field's multiple and often competing and intersecting identities and histories. As ways of knowing, they offer a broad framework within which we can understand not just how our agenda of attention is formed and changes as our 'reading of the global' shifts. Nor do they simply help us to grasp and craft the epistemological tensions and intermixing of epistemologies existing within the field.

The three traditions are crucial because as different ways of writing about our past, present and future, they help us understand who the main protagonists are in our scholarship and how we should expect them to behave: the different beginnings of our comparative educations, their continuities as well as their ruptures, their presences as well as their absences. Stated differently, they are crucial because they unveil the underlying values of our work, facilitating critical reflections on the issue of whose power we are historically and politically reproducing, or opposing, in and through this work. Wight's traditions pose, above all, another difficult puzzle for the future: how do we write about the field in ways that are not simply guided by the optimism of rationalism nor the moral passion of revolutionism, but that also include a realist(ic) flavour without its cynicism?

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